

The My Lai Case

The My Lai massacre was the largest single American atrocity in the ground war in Vietnam. In 1969, the exposure of what had happened and the search for explanations prompted troubling questions about the moral risks the war posed for the United States.

◀◀ BEFORE

Atrocities such as targeting innocent civilians and torturing prisoners were not new to American history or limited to one side of the conflict.

A VIOLENT HISTORY

In the 19th century, US soldiers killed innocent Native American women and children in massacres such as the one at **Wounded Knee**.

MASSACRE IN HUE

In the **1968 struggle** for control of Hue, NVA forces murdered hundreds of civilian residents, who were buried in mass graves.

In 1971, controversial court martial proceedings captured the attention of the nation. The trials revolved around an incident some years before, in 1968, when an infantry company had killed 504 unresisting Vietnamese civilians in a hamlet known as My Lai, in the village of Son My. The event had been covered up by the participants and their immediate commanders for a year and a half, until Ron Ridenhour—a soldier who had learned what happened from men in the company—began writing letters to the Army, members of Congress, and even the president. Soon, *Life* magazine and CBS News were reporting the story. Ridenhour's persistence prompted an official inquiry in 1969. Led by Lieutenant General William Peers, their report in March 1970 recommended that no fewer than 28 officers be charged.

Details emerge

The court martial that began in November 1970 charged only 14 officers, who were called upon to explain their actions. The story that emerged was bleak. As part of the post-Tet operations in 1968, a task force, including three infantry companies, was sent to Son My. Charlie Company, under Captain Ernest Medina, landed outside My Lai on March 16. Expecting to find a Viet Cong unit, two platoons entered with guns firing and began to round up the inhabitants.

By noon, all of the men, women, and children in the hamlet were dead. The only US casualty was self-inflicted. The commanding general reported a victory with 128 killed, but there were no hostile forces present. Within the division, it was a secret that My Lai was cold-blooded brutality, which included rape as well as murder.

Evidence and guilt

The courts martial at Fort Benning, Georgia, would last four months, as the testimonies of 91 witnesses were heard, and documents, depositions, and photographs were scrutinized by the prosecutors. Thirteen of the officers charged were acquitted owing to lack of evidence. One officer was tried on charges of a cover-up and acquitted for the same reason.

The blame for My Lai was laid on the shoulders of the man who ordered the shootings: Lieutenant William Calley. He was tried for the murder of 109 civilians, but that number later dropped to 102. Calley said he had only been following orders, and claimed that his only crime was to value the lives of his troops above those of the enemy. Witnesses told a